

WEEK 10 · WORK

CLASS 3

Work, Play, and Global Capitalism

READING 1

“Chapter 5: Disrupted Landscapes of Production and Reproduction”
in *Growing Up Global* – Katz

Growing Up Global: Economic Restructuring and Children's Everyday Lives | Katz

Week 10, Class 3

Chapter 5: Disrupted Landscapes of Production and Reproduction — pp. 134–152

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5. Disrupted Landscapes of Production and Reproduction

When the aim of labor is not a particular product, standing in a particular relation to the particular needs of the individual, but money, wealth in its general form, then firstly, the individual's industriousness knows no bounds, it is indifferent to its particularity and takes on every form which serves its purpose.

—Karl Marx, *Grundrisse*

Maybe it was the lorries. Maybe it was something else—the plumpness of those woolly sheep, the disappearance of the doleibs, something in the air. But virtually every child—girl or boy, rich or poor, student or not—went to market in the course of their “geodramas.”¹ No matter what the plot or how long its duration, at one point or another each child put a miniature sheep, goat, or even a cow in a toy truck and went to town to sell it. Getting and spending were already a big part of the game in Howa, and selling off animal wealth was one way to “play.” To paraphrase Marx (1973), money had entered the community and then it became the community. Marx was describing the erosive and constitutive effects of the money form associated with ascendent capitalism. These effects were readily apparent in Howa.

In the wake of the Suki Project, money was fast becoming the “generalized representative of wealth” and the medium of all social exchange, dissolving old means and intentions of production and becoming the connective tissue that bound people to one another and the broader society. The children in Howa were keenly aware of the dissolution and reconstitution underway in their community as they engaged in reproducing—remaking—it in their own ways. Their games, their conversations, their desires, as much as their daily routines at school or work, were all a part of the process

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This much I hope has been clear from the foregoing chapters, but things were changing dramatically as these children came of age. What had Howa become as a community? What was its relationship to Sudan and the rest of the world? What were the relationships between children's everyday practices and the terrain of production; between their learning and knowledge and the social relations of their community; and between disruptions in the production of space and nature at different scales and the material social practices through which children constructed their identities and negotiated the conditions of their everyday lives then and as they grew older?

To begin to answer these questions, this chapter will focus on disruptions and reconfigurations in the production of space, nature, and social life in the household, the village, the nation, and more generally. I will address displacements in the relationship between production and social reproduction, focusing on the production and exchange of knowledge to examine evidence of, prospects for, and responses to deskilling in Howa, particularly among young people. Finally, I will explore responses to these sweeping changes in Howa, and the ways these changes may lead to new constructions of identity and rework the geographies of everyday life.

Altered Relations of Production and Reproduction

Children in Howa, like children everywhere, produced their identities as they made their way through their everyday lives. Absorbing and making their own the cultural forms and practices of their families and community, children acquired the knowledge and skills shared locally in connection with production and reproduction. While these practices and their social matrix are always fluid and potentially unstable, in most historical geographies everyday life is more constant than precarious. By the 1980s this was not the case in Howa; earlier practices, expectations, and assurances of social life, however hard won and fragile, were no longer so secure. The productions of space, nature, and social life associated with the Suki Agricultural Project were most directly responsible for these changes in everyday life, but it is important to remember that they were only the most obvious local manifestation of much broader changes afoot in Sudan and elsewhere. As money becomes the community, the process dissolves older community forms by ratcheting apart, disrupting, and rewiring preexisting social relations of production and reproduction.

Suki Agricultural Project

Money became the metric of social life in Howa as insistently as the Suki Project redefined the local political economy and ecology. As detailed in previous chapters, the project, begun in 1971, absorbed most of the peasant agriculturalists living in Howa and engaged them in contract farming as tenants in the scheme. Tenants were required

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project lands. Most existing farm plots and their surrounds were leveled and graded as part of the project, pushing the cultivation of other crops and nontenant agriculture to lesser and more distant areas, along with various complementary economic activities, such as grazing or forestry. These shifts made it much more difficult for farmers to work outside of the cash nexus, in essence gearing their production toward exchange value rather than goods, such as sorghum, for their households' consumption. Tenant households, meanwhile, had higher needs for cash than was customary before the project because a greater number of farm inputs were required and had to be purchased. Finally, the political-economic and political-ecologic changes brought about by the Suki Project transformed many formerly free, self-produced, or commonly available goods into commodities, including, for instance, sorghum and fuelwood, thereby exacerbating the need for cash across the board. In these ways and others, the Suki Project was the definitive impulse propelling Howa into the capitalist money economy in its relations of production and reproduction.

Money Becomes the Community

In a chapter on money in the *Grundrisse*, Marx vividly explains the social relations brought about and represented by money as a general form. He notes that when money enters a community as a “generalized representative of wealth and as individual exchange value,” it alters the social relations and object of labor such that labor is commodified and becomes wage labor. The object of wage labor is not a particular product (or use value) but money (exchange value), and money in turn purchases commodities produced through social labor. This situation “is the elementary precondition of bourgeois society.” The transformation from subsistence to bourgeois society is often provoked by the introduction of commodities that encourage new needs and desires among a particular population and draw growing numbers into relations of monetized exchange. Money itself becomes the “*real community*” because “it is the general substance of survival for all” and the integument that joins everyone (Marx 1973, 225, emphasis in the original). This process was heightened in Howa by the shifts produced by the agricultural project and its entailments. In each of my visits to the village over a period of fifteen years, money, rather than particular products or other forms of wealth, such as grain or animals, increasingly became the object of labor. As the need for money expanded incessantly, so, too, did the range of tasks people undertook to get it. This was also anticipated by Marx, who noted that when the aim of labor is money rather than a particular product, “the individual’s industriousness knows no bounds” (224). He could have been describing Howa.

Disruptions

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brought about by the agricultural project, all of them were accelerated by the shifts associated with the Suki Project and the larger social relations of production and reproduction with which it was associated. Among the most important of these disruptions in Howa were commodification, the monetization of the local economy, socioeconomic differentiation, labor migration, the expansion of education, and the separation of work and play. Each of these represents an incursion of money into social relations and the commodification of such things as labor, knowledge, and time.

Commodification

Many goods that had been freely available or commonly held in Howa were fast becoming commodities within the first decades of the project. Sorghum, formerly self-produced, was fully commoditized in Howa by its exclusion from the Suki Project. Its price zoomed up 2000 percent during the first decade that most local agriculturalists had stopped growing it.² The appropriation of land by the project also limited and ultimately led to the degradation of pastures in the vicinity. The devegetation and shrinkage of grazing lands stressed the local livestock population, which suffered periodic losses associated with poor dry-season grazing and drought. The trend exacerbated a tendency toward the commodification of meat that had been underway since the establishment of two butcher stalls in the village during the 1960s. Prior to their establishment, which effectively commodified meat locally, meat was less readily available in Howa, though animals were relatively abundant. Likewise, the appropriation of so much forested area into project lands seriously curtailed the availability of wood in the vicinity. As demand for woodfuel remained unaltered and even increased with local population growth while forestry practices remained largely the same, wood, too, was gradually commodified in Howa. While those who could afford to purchase wood and charcoal occasionally did, the shift enabled others—often young people—to make money on the sale of fuelwood. Finally, as some households had more disposable cash and others a more acute need for it, water became a bit of a commodity as well. About fifteen children and teens routinely sold water in the village to supplement their households' earnings. The dollar or so they made each day made a difference to their families' budgets.

On another front, as some residents accumulated wealth and diversified their economic activities, an increasing number of small shops were opened in the village and a growing number of trucks began plying trade routes in the region. Several trucks went daily from the village to nearby market towns taking local residents to sell, buy, or trade various goods, and returning with an expanded range of commodities, such as fresh fruits and vegetables, to sell. The dozen or so general merchandise shops that did business in Howa all had approximately the same limited inventories, including tinned tomatoes, flip-flops, cigarettes, batteries, school supplies, and a range of dry goods. Peo-

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increasing in number and each stocked a broader range of consumer goods than village shops had sold only a decade before. The fact that Howa was able to support a dozen or so shops and that their inventories were growing in size and variety suggests not only the enhanced significance of commodities of various sorts in everyday life, but the increased monetization of the local economy.

Between the commodification of goods, such as sorghum, wood, meat, and to a lesser extent, water, and wider access to enlarged realms of trade, the importance of money grew. Its power made the effects of socioeconomic differentiation more apparent as certain people began to consume at new levels, while others found staple goods like sorghum less affordable everyday. But, wherever one stood in the economic spectrum, money had become a strong lure, and there was a fairly general desire to have more of it.

Monetization

With commodification and the production demands of the agricultural project, which placed a serious burden on tenants to come up with cash in order to procure agricultural inputs, the monetization of the local economy galloped ahead. As Marx (1973) anticipated, labor—itsself commodified with the expansion of capitalist relations of production and reproduction—was directed increasingly toward exchange rather than a particular use value or accomplishment, and money came to define a growing number of relationships and exchanges, including those within families. But the process by which money became the community was as intensely international as it was local. The “invisible hand” was everywhere. As capitalist relations of production expanded in the village, the broader economy of Sudan began to seriously founder, along with many others in Africa and elsewhere in the “third world.” These problems, associated with global economic restructuring as well as with clientelism, corruption, and the persistence of the structural inequalities of colonialism and its “developmentalist” descendants, had local repercussions.

The various strategies for postcolonial “development,” which in Sudan continued to be led by the expansion of cash crops for export, had not produced sufficient income at the national scale to begin to repay a broad and growing array of bilateral and multilateral debts. Sudan’s “debt trap” deepened and grew as its economy stalled and foundered. During the first decade of the Suki Project (between 1970 and 1981), for instance, Sudan’s external public debt went from .3 billion to 4.8 billion dollars, increasing from 15.8 to an astonishing 59.3 percent of the GNP (Walton and Seddon 1994, 184). To help ensure repayment to a range of northern financial institutions and states, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) instituted Sudan’s first structural adjustment program (SAP) in 1978. As is by now well known, SAPs are generally predicated on the removal of food subsidies, the emphasis of export-based agriculture, currency devaluations, and broad decreases in public spending. In Sudan these measures provoked the

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the country, including rural areas, which were, of course, hard hit by the SAPs through measures that removed subsidies on staples, such as sugar, and altered production relations in many irrigation schemes. The latter was accomplished in part through the introduction of the “individual account system,” which had been pioneered by the Suki Project (see Ali 1985a, b; Bernal 1991). Part of the increased price of sorghum, but by no means all, can also be traced to structural adjustment. In the absence of price controls, sorghum prices increased dramatically after each devaluation imposed by the IMF. But sorghum prices were also seriously affected by price gouging on the part of the mechanized farmers of eastern Sudan, who controlled an increasingly large share of its production and frequently chose to market it to the oil-rich states or smuggle it to neighboring countries such as Chad and Ethiopia, where it commanded a much higher price than it did domestically (Ali 1985a).³

The debilitating effects of the expansion of capitalist relations of production in Howa were thus worsened by the fact that as the local economy was more fully monetized, the economy of Sudan was entering a deeper and deeper crisis. The effects of the crisis distorted the normalized trajectory of monetization and threw a monkey wrench into the path of capital accumulation across geographic scales, but more to the point, they also compounded the squeeze experienced by people in Howa in the face of commodification and the monetization of so many forms of exchange.

Differentiation

These changes, together with those associated more directly with the Suki Project, exacerbated already existing socioeconomic distinctions between households as they instigated new and more ferocious patterns of differentiation. The agricultural project underscored old and created new forms of inequality in Howa in three key ways. First, from the outset there were fewer tenancies to distribute than there were households. Some householders—whether by their own choice or not—did not receive tenancies and were thereby cut out of a key and ascendant economic activity in the village. Second, and along the same lines, because there was a fixed number of tenancies available to residents of Howa, when new households were formed they could rarely acquire one. Tenancies tended to be kept within a family, but even then they were not frequently available to change hands for demographic reasons. Parents of adult children were often quite young and thus remained economically active themselves for many years; at the same time most households included several sons who would eventually vie for a tenancy (see O'Brien 1984). Third, not all tenancies were created equal. Because of the vagaries of location and the subtle distinctions in the land allocated, some fields were more productive than others, and these differences were self-reinforcing. Where success enabled some farmers to avail themselves of additional means to boost their productivity, such as mechanizing certain operations or hiring labor during periods of

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whom engaged in illegal crop-mortgaging activities. In these ways social differentiation begot further differentiation.⁴

These social divisions were often built on longstanding ones of more modest size. Some families had accumulated wealth long before the Suki Project through building large herds, participating in private cotton schemes along the Blue Nile, and/or engaging in trade or money lending, and this gave them an advantage in all subsequent economic activities, including tenant farming. Those who had tenancies in private pump schemes along the Blue Nile, for instance, were given priority in the allocation of Suki tenancies. Several of them, and others with *wasta* (social connections) not only managed to get more than one tenancy—in some cases registering them to wives or infant sons—but they appeared to have gotten the best ones as well. More privileged residents seemed to have received a disproportionate share of the tenancies closest to the village. At the very least, these fields were the most convenient, but they were also closest to the major irrigation canals and this made them first in line to receive water. Shortfalls or problems along the canals, which were frequent (see Euroconsult 1988; Suki Agricultural Corporation 1997), were other tenants' problems. Apart from reinforcing old socioeconomic disparities, the project fostered new ones through controlling access to land and other productive resources and the peculiarities of its accounting and other systems of operation.

Finally, socioeconomic differentiation was exacerbated by the availability of labor or other forms of support from members of the extended family and household, counterbalanced by the nature of their dependencies and needs. Despite the resourcefulness and often exhausting hard work done by so many in Howa, growing impoverishment was the lot of most village households. Income from the tenancies was inadequate for most households, but very few tenants (6 percent) supplemented it with regular, permanent, wage labor. Rather, people worked as independent woodcutters, charcoal makers, crafts people, petty entrepreneurs, and the like, either in the interstices of their agricultural work or in the off-seasons (67 percent of all tenants supplemented their incomes in this way). Only 37 household heads (11 percent of all households), tenants and not, were regular wage workers, while 144 men and women in the village reported working at least occasionally as agricultural laborers. Over 54 percent of these day laborers were women who, with adolescent girls and children of both genders, predominated in all harvest work, especially cotton picking. In most village households, this mixture of economic strategies enabled survival but not much gain, especially in the face of an increasingly commodified life. Within a decade of the project's inception, there was common agreement among adults in Howa that local socioeconomic disparities had not only become more widespread, but they had become heightened as well.

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One of the early effects of the production relations and seasonal labor demands of the project, for instance, was the diminished importance of communal work parties, or *nefir*. While in the past, villagers cooperated to accomplish various agricultural tasks, the Suki Project was predicated on household self-sufficiency, mechanization, and hiring field hands as necessary. While I never heard anything from project authorities that specifically discouraged *nefir*, and indeed they persisted in Howa albeit with less frequency, the compressed time and intensity of certain tasks were not conducive to work sharing among tenant households because everyone was under pressure to accomplish appointed tasks according to a tight schedule. In addition, those strapped for cash, tenants and not, scrambled to find remunerative work in and outside the project. In this way everyday forms of labor were commodified as people increasingly bought and sold labor power among neighbors and friends.

Labor dynamics were reworked within the family as well. With almost all tenancies allocated to men in the village, the project administration assumed the availability of household labor and the ability of men to mobilize the labor of their wives and children. They were not wrong. Nevertheless, the agricultural labor of women and children in the cotton and groundnut fields represented a marked shift from the labor dynamics that had prevailed previously. While villagers indicated that children had helped their fathers in the cultivation of sorghum and sesame, these crops were substantially less labor-intensive than either cotton or groundnuts, and this difference was reflected in children's everyday lives. Children and adolescent boys helped to take up the slack on several of the tasks that were new to the project or had been attenuated on account of it. Among these were the maintenance of the irrigation ditches, furrowing and sowing (sesame was broadcast), and the mandatory four weedings of both cotton and groundnuts. Perhaps even more striking, while women had had little to do with the cultivation of sorghum and sesame, they played a significant role in the agricultural project.

The cotton and groundnut harvests were accomplished almost entirely by women, teenaged girls, and children. Cotton picking was the main agricultural task for which labor was hired in Howa, and most of this work was done by local residents. Women, teens, and children worked almost constantly during the cotton and groundnut harvests, earning between US\$.75 and \$1.11 a day on a piece-rate basis.⁵ However minimal the compensation, this income was crucial to many households. Girls' contributions were particularly important in this regard. More than twice as many girls (111) as boys (48) worked as paid field hands in Howa. Most of the women working the harvest were past their prime childbearing years, but some younger women picked cotton with their families. Some even moved their entire households out to their tenancies, staying in temporary field dwellings to maximize their collective labor time. This practice was more prevalent among those whose tenancies were relatively far from the village.

The harvest was the most labor-intensive aspect of cotton (and groundnut) cultivation; over 208 estimated person-days were required to harvest a five-feddan cotton

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agricultural project was carried out by them. Without the relatively cheap labor power of local women and children—including those from their own households—tenants would be hard-pressed to harvest their crops on time. While the success, such as it was, of the agricultural project depended on the ready availability of this labor, the harvest was a two-way street for women; the money they earned in most cases was their own to keep. In this way the commodification of labor associated with the project was contradictory—it simultaneously tapped into patriarchal relations as a means of securing a labor force for the harvest and it loosened the hold on women as they secured another relatively autonomous source of personal income.⁶

While as the foregoing suggests, there was a ready and often tapped labor market in Howa, with the number of available laborers growing as more young men came of age without access to land, this market was increasingly saturated and was in any event casual (see Kevane 1994; O'Brien 1983). The commodification of labor also took place outside of agriculture. Young men without access to tenancies, for instance, occasionally found work in the project offices and workshops. More commonly, young men, including some who had tenancies, worked as day laborers in the nearby market towns of Sennar, Suki, and Dinder. Most of them found work as cargo loaders and carriers on a sporadic basis. Except for the few men in Howa who found employment in the project headquarters in Wad Tuk Tuk, most engagements with the labor market outside of Howa were partial and casual. They suggest a transitional phase in the commodification of labor in Howa.

Despite the growing importance of money in the local economy and the increasing importance of labor “commuting,” there was little labor migration. Only eighteen households (5.4 percent) reported members working elsewhere, almost all in urban areas of Sudan, although larger numbers migrated seasonally for agricultural and other work and a growing number found casual employment in the nearby towns, which they could commute to as necessary. There was virtually no foreign labor migration. In the early years after the first oil shocks, when the expanded wealth of the oil-exporting states made them a magnet for labor migration, most of the Sudanese who migrated to Saudi Arabia and the Gulf States were from urban areas and tended to be more educated than the average population. By the 1980s, as Sudan’s economy continued to sink, its government was overthrown, and the civil war resumed, a growing number of emigrants hailed from more rural areas, particularly from villages along the Nile (see Bernal 1991; Galal el Din 1978). Still, Howa seemed immune. The relatively minimal role of labor migration there suggests both its relative insulation from the larger cash economy and the continued ability of its population to provide for themselves locally, despite the pace of commodification there. The erosive local effects of monetization and the kinds of desire commodification engendered seemed to ensure that it would not be long before Howa produced its own crop of *mugtheribiin* (labor emigrants). Labor migration was in certain ways just the extreme edge of more mundane processes associated with the ascen-

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migration exacerbates many of the trends that engender it because it ups the ante on desire and opens up new standards of consumption and wealth.

Education and the Commodification of Knowledge

The effects of children's increased labor played out in other arenas of their everyday lives. The expectation of "development" is that "modernization" and infrastructural improvements will liberate children and others from various forms of drudgery so that, among other things, child labor will decrease while school attendance and "free" time will increase (see Rodgers and Standing 1981; Cain 1977; Nag, White, and Peet 1978; Tienda 1979; Middleton 1970; but cf. Porter 1996; Levine 1996). I thought as much myself before I lived in Howa. But these sorts of changes are not among the guarantees of "development"—quite the opposite, it seemed. As Marx (1967) made clear in the first volume of *Capital*, the early stages of capital accumulation in any particular place have historically depended on the conscription of child labor. Neither history, nor geography seems to have altered this situation. While the continued importance of child labor in urban and industrial areas of the "third world" is well recognized, my research indicated that capitalist "development" brought about an intensification and expansion of children's work in the countryside as well. Thanks to new cultivation strategies and requirements, environmental degradation, and heightened monetization, the Suki Agricultural Development Project and its entailments led to increases in children's labor, measured both in time spent and in the range of tasks undertaken. Much of this work was undertaken within and for the household. Indeed, children's labor was often a bulwark against hiring labor and thus simultaneously conserved household financial resources and provided a valve on the local labor market that helped keep wage rates down (see O'Brien 1984). In poorer households without the resources to hire labor, children's labor enabled the timely completion of tasks such as clearing, planting, weeding, and harvesting.

The effects of these shifts were uneven and exceeded the realm of agricultural labor. They were more acute for children from the poorest and most marginalized households in Howa, especially nontenants. These children not only added to their households' income, but in providing the means of existence under conditions of increasing commodification, their work enabled their families to avoid cash expenditures. But the nature of the changes underway in Howa tended to increase the labor time of children from wealthier households as well, particularly those headed by tenant-merchants. These children often had broader work responsibilities than others because of their households' economic diversification, which required that work be doled out along particular lines of specialization. Wealthier families tended to groom certain children for particular tasks so that all arenas of the household's work and economic activity—present and future—would be covered "in house."

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While the changes brought about by the project seemed to make it ever more difficult for children in Howa to attend school, the need for formal education as a means to success was felt more sharply there and elsewhere in Sudan. Nevertheless, the significance of schooling in children's lives, as well as its impending importance in future children's lives, felt very much up for grabs. As I've indicated before, only a minority of school-aged boys and almost no girls attended school in Howa as these contradictions emerged. The majority of those who did attend left early because of economic necessity, and very few continued past the sixth grade in the best of circumstances. According to my survey, only 42 percent of those who ever attended school in Howa reached sixth grade, the final year of primary school. While people commonly expressed an appreciation for the alternate futures possible for educated people and for the kinds of knowledge and skills that might be acquired in school, the reality of the pressures of production and reproduction in the everyday lives of most households made school a luxury.⁷

Even among the wealthy in Howa, the relationship to school was ambiguous. While boys from wealthier households commonly attended school, many of them left prior to graduation. The others, like most boys in Howa, did not continue their education in secondary school. In wealthier households, adults seemed to view schooling within the larger strategy of household diversification. School was a way to provide literacy and numeracy skills to selected sons, while others learned how to market livestock, run the family business, manage a truck, oversee agricultural production and the like. Sons groomed in these directions either never attended school or left it after a few years. For these families, more than others in the village, formal education neither functioned, nor was perceived as a means to economic success or status. It was one strategy among many for maintaining and expanding wealth and power.

Although the increased demand for children's labor and earnings in so many households in the decade following Howa's inclusion in the Suki Project apparently led to decreases in the ratio of students to nonenrolled children, it seemed that school enrollment would eventually increase in Howa precisely because of the social and economic changes associated with the project (see O'Brien 1984). But this was only likely to occur when the viability of other forms of learning began to erode. The "glamour" of education was certainly not enough to draw most people into the system, and the appreciation people commonly expressed for formal education seemed more ideal than real. Almost everyone spoke of schooling with high regard, responding to my interview and casual questions as if they had every intent of sending their children to school or wished they could do so, but what they actually did was often a dramatic departure because of necessity or deep ambivalence about the government schools. When I first got to Howa in 1980, the only person from the village ever to go to university tended to walk around like a self-appointed prince. When I would sing songs in praise of him, naively expecting collective pride in this unusual native son, many retorted with thinly

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As more people become disenfranchised and landless, however, the vocational preparation offered by the school was seen more widely as worthwhile—whether the case or not—and was increasingly likely to edge out the various forms and practices of socialization and learning outside it. Added to that, the deepening cultural integration of Howa with the larger social formation, through such things as the proliferation of radios and a few televisions, more travel and improved communications, the social extension service of the agricultural project, and proximity to the project headquarters, would no doubt encourage greater school attendance because that was the position of the urban and professional elite, whose views were increasingly influential in the area. Finally, and intimately connected with the preceding, the cultural forms and practices associated historically with ascending capitalism tend to encourage school enrollment over the long term because of workplace demands for a prepared (and disciplined) labor force, the use of “standards” to screen potential workers, and technological changes that eventually reduce the need for children’s work. My expectation that the role of formal education would increase in Howa was borne out when I returned there in subsequent years. These changes will be discussed in chapters 7 and 8.

School, of course, was not the only way to develop alternate vocational skills and acquire new kinds of knowledge. Young men who came of age and found themselves with few viable work options in the village by the early 1980s most commonly looked in nearby towns and sometimes further afield for employment opportunities. Most of them were unqualified for most forms of employment and found work as day laborers, usually stevedores, picking up what skills were required as they went along. Truck driving was perhaps the most alluring off-farm job for young men and boys in Howa. It was well compensated, the opportunity for independent trade and getting bargains on various commodities was ever present, and the romance of the road was compelling. The way to secure a position as a driver was to serve an apprenticeship as a driver’s assistant. Within a decade of the project’s establishment, several adolescent boys and young men had begun coveted apprenticeships on the dozen or so trucks in Howa. Acquiring new skills and occupations, such as driving or day work in the towns, was of growing importance to young people in Howa excluded from agriculture by the land tenure relations of the project, and from other forms of work by their lack of preparation and the stunted nature of Sudan’s economy.

The shifting role of formal education and the heightened importance of various apprenticeships in people’s everyday lives were among the many disruptions and realignments brought about by the agricultural project and its broader social relations. They represented a commodification of knowledge in several ways. Schooling offered a more specialized body of knowledge whose contours and purveyors were credentialized by the state. Such knowledge has a tendency to be fetishized as a thing in itself, concealing the social relations that simultaneously produce it as such and make it salient as something to be exchanged. Apprenticeships, on the other hand, represented

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was learned in a situated manner in schools was not the formal curriculum, but a particular relationship to learning and knowledge (Lave and Wenger 1991). School knowledge was useful for different ends than the “local knowledge” exchanged between elders and children or among the peer group. School knowledge was tested more formally than the knowledge exchanged in the give-and-take of everyday life, and the formal tests tempered the flow of those deemed “qualified.” The learning associated with practice had no such valve on it, but as its forms and practices were made more superfluous by the changes associated with “development,” commodification, and the degradation of the local environment, the “qualifications” of children in Howa began to seem more perversion than preparation. Yet the outcomes of children’s learning—in school and out—were up for grabs in Howa as the social relations and practices of production and reproduction were unhinged from their previous moorings in the wake of the Suki Project and its attendant shifts. If in ceding ground to the school, parents thought they were better preparing their children for the altered future, their goal was not always achieved. Apprentices to truck drivers and in the towns were better off, but their numbers remained quite small. Most young people coming of age in Howa during the 1980s seemed well prepared for futures that were likely to elude them, and underprepared for what most likely lay ahead.

Commodification of Time

If the commodification of knowledge was one aspect of the rise in formal education and the eroding viability of other forms of learning, the commodification of time accompanied the production relations associated with the Suki Project. The commodification of time is one of the hallmarks of the ascendance of capitalism (Thompson 1967). While most people in Howa still organized their daily rounds of work without recourse to clock time, its seasonal tempo was metered to some extent by the project authorities, who distributed particular inputs at set times and scheduled other operations according to the availability of personnel, supplies, and machinery, or the timetables of either the project as a whole or the government marketing boards. Unlike the situation prior to the project, when farmers responded to the arrival of the rains and other seasonal shifts, the scheduling of events in the project often missed or clashed with environmental cues or conditions. This situation notwithstanding, most tenants and others still had relative autonomy in scheduling their work and leisure, at least on a day-to-day basis.

Children were more constrained in this autonomy, but that was nothing new. Parents set children’s work schedules according to their own convenience and children by and large complied, though not always happily. Nevertheless, as the previous chapter laid out, with increases in children’s work time and changes in the kinds of work they were responsible for doing, there was a growing separation between the activities of work

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time and the consignment of play or leisure outside of what “counts.” This change, which was underway during the years I worked in Howa, marks a significant alteration of everyday life there, and suggests the breadth of disruptions in the social relations of production and reproduction that were set in motion most significantly by the Suki Project and the ways “money was becoming the community.” Each of the disruptions detailed here fueled these political-economic changes as much as they were set in motion by them.

Consequences of Disruptions for Children’s Everyday Lives

The processes of socioeconomic differentiation, commodification, and environmental deterioration were interconnected and had strong effects—individually and collectively—on production and reproduction in Howa. These effects were likely to have serious repercussions both on the children as they came of age and on the larger social formations within which they lived their lives, contemporaneously and in the future. The shifting ground of that future was far broader than Howa—indeed the disruptions there were connected intricately with changes in the national, regional, and global arenas.

Given these disruptions across geographic scale, along with the more immediately felt constellation of practices and social relations of production and reproduction associated with the Suki Project, it appeared that many of the skills and much of the knowledge acquired by the children were unlikely to be of much use in their futures. The very sociosymbolic, political-ecologic, and political-economic relations that created the conditions in which children acquired and used their formidable environmental knowledge were creating conditions that would undermine any possibility that young people could use this knowledge effectively as they came of age. What children learned about work and the environment, and how they learned it, seemed, paradoxically, to be a form of deskilling. Young people in Howa were learning how to work a system that was under erosion, if not complete erasure. While paradoxical spaces or moments, like play or mimesis, encompass possibilities of disruption and transformation, they also reflect painful contradictions (see Rose 1993; Desbiens 1999), and these are important to understand.

Changes in the Production and Exchange of Knowledge and Skills

One of the signal areas of change was in the cultural forms and practices associated with children’s environmental learning and knowledge. The changing nature of their everyday lives alone suggests altered opportunities and practices for the acquisition and use of environmental knowledge. But the broader shifts that were taking place in Howa, affecting, among other things, the relationships among the household, peer group, state, market, and workplace as arenas of social reproduction, along with the practices of

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Children's everyday environmental interactions were altered by the disruptions in the local political ecology and political economy. They spent an increasing amount of time working in activities that produced an income or saved household expenditures for newly commodified goods. Among the most important activities here were agricultural work, fuelwood provision, selling water, and odd jobs, such as food hawking. Other tasks had long consumed children's time, but environmental problems had made them more time consuming. Most significantly affected by environmental degradation were herding, providing fuelwood, and gathering wild foods and other resources from the local environs. Finally, gendered household labor dynamics persistently elicited a substantial work contribution from children because keeping the ideals of *purdah* placed a relatively large burden on children, who did tasks that tended to be women's responsibilities in other parts of Africa, such as water and fuelwood provision, agriculture, and petty trading. The disruptions engendered by commodification and the heightened monetization of the local economy also increased children's work across the board in Howa by simultaneously introducing new tasks and prodding a greater orientation toward cash. The problems created by these shifts during a time of deepening economic crisis at the national level and sharpening socioeconomic differentiation at the local scale resulted in unequal increases in children's work and widening differences among children in the sorts of responsibilities they had.

The other disruptions in the social relations of production and reproduction were more specific to children: the changing valence of formal schooling and the growing separation between work and play. Children's play, alone or among their friends, for example, was an important means of environmental learning in Howa, and despite the pace and scale of the changes taking place there, the peer group remained a fairly stable setting for learning about and using environmental knowledge. Among their peers, children's work and play frequently remained bound—temporally, conceptually, and metaphorically—and their learning seemed vitally reinforced by this association. However, as I have noted, the thick ties between work and play in Howa showed signs of fraying. Most centrally, the increased time children spent in tasks related to income generation and capital accumulation often left them little time for play in general and removed them from the company of their friends. This, of course, was not uniformly the case, as the experience of shepherds attests. But many times when I observed children assisting their parents in the fields, the pressure to get a particular task done was palpable, and I occasionally saw parents impatient with children "wasting time" trapping birds, snacking, or otherwise "goofing off." This attitude reflected the ways that time itself was taking on a new meaning with, among other things, the extralocal scheduling of tasks and other work rules associated with the project. If work and play are separated and children's peer groups become settings for play alone, they are gradually isolated from the larger society caught up with work. With these changes, the balance between work and play as activities of environmental learning and interaction shifts as well.

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inessential activity consigned to inferior symbolic status because of its separation from work is surely part of the deracination of everyday life that capitalist “modernization” brings (see Aronowitz 1973, 59 ff). Discrete from work, play remains important as a means of socialization and learning—and may even become more important. Play divorced from work, however, is less grounded in the general experience of the community, and in this way often is viewed as inconsequential—a minor practice. Of course, with great difficulty and unsure results, minor practices are able to rework “major” ones from within, and this is precisely the immanent power of children’s play (see Katz 1996). This understanding of play dovetails with my analysis of it as a mimetic practice.

Contemporary and Future Consequences of Deskilling

All of these changes prompted inequalities in skills acquisition among children along various axes, including fathers’ occupation, household socioeconomic status, and gender. At the same time the consequences of having acquired various skills or learned particular kinds of knowledge were up for grabs and uncertain at best. Children learning to be farmers—all the better for the increased labor demands of irrigated cultivation—would lack the land resources to employ their skills and knowledge as adults. On the other hand, those who were in school and learning material at a remove from the environmental conditions of Howa were likely to find themselves both ill-prepared for the kinds of work available locally and inadequately educated for other vocations. Because men’s work roles were changing more rapidly than women’s, these concerns were likely to be more serious for boys. However, the implications of girls not acquiring a basic environmental education may prove to be more important for the village over time.

The consequences of these inequalities and differences in the ways children acquired and had a chance to use environmental knowledge were serious. If children in Howa learned most about the environment by participating in the work of agriculture and animal husbandry, and this pattern of learning favored boys and the children of tenants in particular, then the changes taking place in Howa were likely to have multiple and uneven effects. First, if, as appeared likely, men increasingly left the village in search of work, then women would be left to provide for their families’ subsistence on a daily basis. Under these circumstances, women’s relative inexperience with farming and their lack of training in the sequencing and coordination of agricultural practices may hinder their ability to provide for their families’ reproduction on a sustained basis and lead, at least temporarily, to declines in rural productivity. This eventuality, however, could radically transform women’s “place” in Howa and lead, among other things, to *purdah* unraveling a bit as women engage in agricultural or other forms of production outside the home.⁸ As women changed their positions in the relations of production and reproduction and gained experience in other realms of work, they were likely not only to turn shortfalls in productivity around, but to

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Second, if male labor migration leaves women to bring up their families largely on their own, as has been the case in many parts of Africa and increasingly so in Sudan, women's lack of environmental learning and inexperience in agriculture, combined with the intensity of the work itself, may limit their ability to teach this knowledge and its associated skills to their children. In this way, previous educational gaps as a result of gender, earlier instances of deskilling, and the results of differentiation further break down the general structure, content, and exchange of environmental knowledge, and may lead to yet greater differentiation and the marginalization of much of the remaining population. By these means, the household becomes thwarted as a site for reproducing the kinds of local knowledge and social actors that ensured survival previously, and increasingly becomes the locus for reproducing capitalism, both intentionally and unintentionally. Herein lies another paradoxical moment, for while household practices may indeed begin to reproduce capitalism, they are also treasure troves of resilience, especially when the survival of household members is at stake. The agile responses of households in Howa facing the vagaries of the agricultural project promised as much. Even more to the point perhaps, the experience of female-headed households in other parts of the world—similar and not—suggests that the women in Howa will find in themselves and their community a reservoir of dormant knowledge and other strengths to make something work out of their changed circumstances. Some of the sting of deskilling is undone as reskilling takes place, even if its individual toll is often enormous.

Nevertheless, rural productivity may decline as the changing relations of production and reproduction, along with the ensuing redefinition of vocational skill, dislocate the household as the center of production and reproduction. These dual dislocations have resulted historically in the depopulation of the household as waged work is found outside of the home and as children leave in growing numbers to attend school. As a result, less labor is available to the rural household to maintain previous levels of agricultural productivity, and the household is relegated to a secondary "domestic" status. As waged work increases in relative importance, unremunerated segments of the population, predominantly women, children, and old people, lose power in relation to waged workers (see Dalla Costa 1972, 21–22).

These changed conditions and the altered material social practices accompanying them were likely to be of serious consequence for the children as they came of age and tried to find their own footing on this new and shifting ground. Most boys, I have argued, were not likely to have access to land because of the constricted land tenure relations of the Suki Project. The agricultural project not only dominated the production landscape, but its structure sharply limited the number of tenancies available for new registrants. Both circumstances, coupled with household and village demographics, effectively proletarianized the population and were likely to drive young men to leave the village in growing numbers. While casual employment in the fields was not enough

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peak labor demand. These seasonal demands were likely to affect patterns of migration and the contours of proletarianization. In the long run, the broad changes underway in Howa and Sudan might lead to an adult population unable or unwilling to undertake the work associated with the Suki Project, at least on its old terms. As the primary arena of work shifts from agriculture to nonfarm employment, environmental knowledge—along with the ecologies of its acquisition and use—was likely to become less important and more piecemeal in Howa. If dislocation or deskilling alone would no doubt lead to declines in agricultural productivity, the two together were sure to.

In sum, the changes underway in Howa, connected broadly to incorporation in the agricultural project and other shifts in the material social practices of everyday life, were leading to the destabilization of the household as a site of production and reproduction, possibly spiraling declines in rural productivity, an intensification of local impoverishment and with it socioeconomic differentiation, and an erosive process of deskilling that promised to exacerbate all of the other problems. These effects were made worse by the grueling inhospitableness of the Sudanese national economy, as well as global economic restructuring. Ground to a pulp by transnational political economics and domestic self-destruction, the national economy was incapable of absorbing more than a handful of the thousands it was driving from the countryside. At the same time, time-space compression spurred by the increasing monetization of the local economy and the commodifications associated with it, folded young people ever more tightly into an economy of desire, made more acute by their distance from what that economy offered and more poignant by the sense that they were jettisoned just as they were engaged by this broader realm of desire and exchange. The issues associated with the simultaneity of the compression and expansion of the experienced economy will be taken up in the concluding chapters. What was clear in the midst of all this was that just a decade into the Suki Project, young people in Howa were being catapulted out of their community into an intensely uncertain future.

A Conclusion or Thoughts toward “Displacements”?

I initially chose to examine children’s learning and knowledge because I thought the production and exchange of knowledge would be an arena rife with the evidence of resistance. I thought I might find resistance by examining closely what and how parents consciously taught their children, the kinds of knowledge children shared among themselves, and the diverse relationships people had with schooling. While this remains a good supposition, the situation, not surprisingly, was more complicated. The cultural forms and practices of children’s learning and knowledge form one of the fault lines that traverse social reproduction and transformation. This line, perhaps more than others, is fissured by the distances between intention and actuality, between hope and achievement, and between effort and circumstance. Thus, while parents in Howa wanted their

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In this paradoxical time-space that propels people forward and pulls them backward at the same time, anything can happen. Gardening along fault lines is risky business, but they make for fertile grounds, where people can sow what they know. What will grow and how it gets harvested is anybody's guess. What I have tried to get at here is that people's responses to almost overwhelming changes in the political economy, political ecology, and sociosymbolic forms and practices in and around Howa have not just been those of immiseration and capitulation, but extraordinary resilience and reformulation as well. These practices—which I prefer to distinguish as resilience, reworking, and resistance, rather than presume that quite varied responses are all resistance or homogenize their distinct qualities—are interconnected (see chapter 9). Their boundaries are blurred and passages between them can be almost imperceptible. They are rooted in and help produce what James Scott (1985) calls “dignity” among people facing grueling conditions in their everyday lives that are not of their own choosing or creation. If Scott, who does not distinguish between what I am calling resilience, reworking, and resistance, is careful to define the limits of such counterhegemonic practices, he is more intent on how critical they are for undergirding subsequent broader oppositional practices. Beyond their socially reinforcing and fortifying role, these practices also act in and on the world, sometimes changing it. In Howa—where changed patterns of household labor enabled sustenance, and incipient social forms, such as new attitudes toward schooling, anticipated new conditions of production—the amalgam of people's responses to the disruptions of their everyday lives worked as a bulwark against the changing productions of space, nature, and social life heralded most decisively by the Suki Project, and made their progress a struggle far from won.